

TILL POLLS DO US PART

UPA



LALU AND PASWAN

PARVEEN NEGI

The Congress president may be all set to launch her election campaign with a rally in Davanagere in Karnataka early next week, but the war cry is fast losing its punch with most of its regional alliances failing to come through. The unkindest cut of them all came from one who had been the kindest to them—Congress President Sonia Gandhi's favourite ally and RJD chief Lalu Prasad

Yadav. In a surprise move, he hugged his *bête noire* and LJP chief Ram Vilas Paswan and announced a seat-sharing arrangement in Bihar that left the Congress with mere crumbs—one seat less than what the party had got during the 2004

alliance with Paswan and Lalu. Lalu gave 12 seats to Paswan, 25 to his party and only three to the Congress. A dazed Congress in-charge of Bihar, Union Minister Sushilkumar Shinde, could only recall how Lalu had been the first to defend Sonia as the *bahu* of the nation when the BJP launched an attack against her. In retaliation, the Congress has given Lalu only two seats in Jharkhand and none to Paswan.

Lalu's attitude is not inexplicable. For long, he and the NCP chief Sharad Pawar have been asking the Congress to fight the elections under the UPA umbrella. The Congress refused and instead suggested that each party work out its individual alliance at the state level, which is precisely what Lalu has done. Similarly, Pawar is getting impatient at the delay in firming up the Congress-NCP alliance in Maharashtra. In a not-so-subtle show of muscle flexing, Pawar responded to the Samajwadi Party's (SP) overtures and the two have struck a bilateral alliance. Equally miffed with the Congress's big brotherly attitude is the SP which has gone ahead and announced candidates for 75 of the 80 seats in Uttar Pradesh, indicating that it was not going to concede the Congress's demand for 20 seats. And though the party has struck an alliance with Mamata Banerjee in West Bengal, it has been on the fiery Trinamool leader's terms. The party is buoyed by an internal survey that shows it is getting 150 seats. That is chicken feed for a party that has in the past won over 400 seats. But remember, these are meltdown times.

by Priya Sahgal

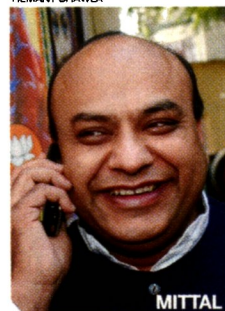
A Costly Poll-eve HARAKIRI

At a time when they should have been fighting the common enemy outside, BJP leaders are busy fighting enemies within. Party General Secretary Arun Jaitley's is miffed that Sudhanshu Mittal, who used to make the best wedding pandals in town, has been chosen to head the party's campaign in the North-east. Since then, Jaitley has been boycotting all the meetings of the Central Election Committee which decides the candidates for the Lok Sabha polls.

Jaitley's obstinacy is an embarrassment for prime minister-in-waiting L.K. Advani, who is in a Catch-22 situation. He cannot put pressure on Mittal to resign as it could lead to major trouble with ally Asom Gana Parishad (AGP), with whom Mittal has good relations. After Orissa, the BJP has learnt the importance of lending an ear to allies. Party leaders are trying hard to persuade him to step down, but Mittal, an old ABVP hand and associate of the late Pramod Mahajan, has reportedly said that he could open several cans of worms. On March 18, he left for Guwahati to attend a coordination meeting with the AGP, an indication that the BJP takes his threat seriously.

by Bhavna Vij-Aurora

HEMANT CHAWLA



MITTAL

JAITLEY



HEMANT CHAWLA